

OLIVIA HILL-COUSINS

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(LinkedIn)

PhD Moral Mind/Brain and AI Ethics
Researcher
Exeter, England, United Kingdom

A PhD candidate at the University of Exeter, with a strong psychology theoretical and, further developing, research background. I am interested in working towards a career in research, developing advanced statistical and methodological techniques, whilst maintaining my interest in moral cognition and AI.

EDUCATION

PhD University of Exeter, Psychology **2023 – Present, End Date: 2027**

Thesis (Working Title): “AI on Trial: Do We Judge AI and Human Moral Action in the Same Way Cognitively?”

EPSRC funded scholarship examining judgements of human versus AI’s moral decisions/acts.

Supervisors: Dr Joseph Sweetman, Dr Edmond Awad, Dr Cassandra Lowe, Dr Alexander Shaw and Dr Joanne Smith (All based in the University of Exeter).

BSc University of Exeter, Psychology with Study Abroad* **2019-2023**
(First Class)

Thesis: ““Do Psychopaths Know Right From Wrong? The Role of Boldness, Disinhibition and Meanness in Psychopaths’ Moral Judgements””

Tutor: Dr Joseph Sweetman

Modules included in Clinical Neuroscience (Brains, Drugs and Psychiatry), Applied Social Psychology (Health, Environment and Society), Processes of Human Memory, Contemporary Issues in Psychology and Methods and Statistics. Additional credits were earned for Professional Development Experience, in recognition of internship contributions.

* Universiteit Maastricht, Psychology and Neuroscience **2021-2022**
(First Class) – Study Abroad Year of BSc from University of Exeter

Modules included Politics of Decision Making, Consciousness, Cognitive Enhancement, Child Neuropsychology, Adult Neuropsychology, Methods of Cognitive Neuroscience with Practical: Excel for Scientists & Practical: fMRI data analysis, Motivation and Emotion, Action with Practical: Neuronal Basis of Decision Making, and Positive Psychology.

A-Levels Twynham School Sixth Form **2016 - 2019**

Psychology (A), Biology (A), Chemistry (B) & Extended Project Qualification (A*)

GCSEs Bournemouth School for Girls **2011-2016**

11 GCSEs including English Language and Literature, and Mathematics, in addition to MOS Course (Microsoft Office Specialist) passed in Outlook, Excel, PowerPoint and Word.

SCHOLARSHIPS AND AWARDS

EPSRC DTP Studentship	2023
Nominations for “Educator of the Year” Exeter Student Guild Teaching Awards	2023/24
The Exeter Award	2023

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Lead Organiser of ReproducibiliTEA Exeter Journal Club

University of Exeter 2024-Present

- Leading and organising sessions for researchers on open science and reproducibility
- Hosting and teaching sessions on topics such as reproducible code practices
- Providing resources to assist researchers with adhering to open science and reproducibility practices
- Networking with researchers with specialisation/experience with particular practices to provide sessions explaining and demonstrating these practices
- Organising sessions on topics such as qualitative research, reproducible workflows in R, inviting speakers/session leaders external to both the department and university
- Securing funding for refreshments as incentives for in-person sessions
- Collaborating with the department’s Athena Swan team to help provide data on this journal club as a university-wide initiative for PGRs.
- Supporting PGR-led schemes, such as a recent reproducibility check scheme, holding relevant tutorials

PhD Researcher

University of Exeter 2023-Present

- Simulated data and developed code to calculate statistical power using power simulations both for meta-analytic and advanced linear mixed-effects models in R.
- Conducted a multi-level meta-analysis in R, screening for data across platforms such as Web of Science and engaging with leading researchers to obtain additional datasets
- Designed and drew visual elements in Adobe Photoshop, incorporating them as layers into Adobe After Effects to create nearly 300 animated moral dilemmas (e.g. trolley problem). Ensured these were temporally precise for use in EEG experiments
- Created cognitive behavioural tasks in Gorilla and PsychoPy, utilising these animations and applying cognitive methodologies such as the staircase method by embedding algorithms in the Gorilla platform
- Integrated behavioural experiments with crowdsourcing platforms (e.g. Prolific) and managed their execution

- Performed data cleaning, analysis, and presentation in R, and developed a workflow using LaTeX and R to automate manuscript generation directly from data and code, ensuring accuracy and real-time updates

BSc Dissertation

University of Exeter

2023

Supervised by Dr Joseph Sweetman

- Thesis: Investigated whether individuals with psychopathic traits can discern right from wrong and make moral judgements, novelly using an advanced formal model of the moral mind and the triarchic conceptualisation of psychopathy
- Conducted advanced linear mixed-effects analyses and simulations for power sensitivity analyses using R to validate findings
- Achieved an 82 (First-Class) for both the written dissertation and accompanying presentation, reflecting rigorous research and effective communication

Research Intern

University of Exeter

2021 to 2023

- Supported behavioural and neurophysiological research on the moral mind/brain, contributing to experimental design, data collection, and analysis
- Collaborated with the research team to develop stimuli for behavioural, EEG, and fMRI studies, including creating and preparing visual materials for experimental use
- Conducted participant recruitment, testing, and data collection, administering EEG recordings and managing online data collection
- Analysed experimental data using advanced statistical techniques, such as linear mixed-effects modelling in both classical and Bayesian frameworks

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Exeter

2023 to Present

Postgraduate Teaching Assistant, Psychology

- Led tutorial sessions for undergraduate students, covering both lecture and practical components to enhance learning and engagement with the course
- Supervised MSc conversion students who had no prior background in psychology, research, or statistics on their dissertations involving an Advanced EEG Study. Equipped them with the skills to run EEG experiments independently, understand relevant concepts and models, apply statistical techniques, and write up their dissertations
- Facilitated learning in undergraduate and master's-level research practicals and statistics, providing personalised explanations of complex concepts to improve student understanding

Masters students supervised

Gauravi Rajiv Patil, 2024

Rida Kamal Saeed, 2024

Shatabdee Parajuli, 2024

Xinyi Yang, 2024

Dissertation Title: “Understanding the Neurophysiology Supporting Moral Cognitive Processes with EEG”

University of Exeter,

2023-Present

EEG Workshop Lead, Psychology

- Designed and delivered EEG workshops tailored to students at various education levels:
 - Exeter College Psychology Class (A-level students, ages 17-18)
 - BSc Undergraduate Students (Psychology)
 - MSc Conversion Students (Psychology) – with no prior background in psychology or research
 - MSc Research Methods Students (Psychology)
- Demonstrated the use of complex EEG equipment and guided students through hands-on trial sessions to ensure practical proficiency
- Workshop outcomes:
 - Enabled BSc and MSc students to independently run EEG experiments
 - Supported MSc Conversion students to apply this new skillset into their dissertation write-up

PROFESSIONAL EVENTS (INVITED OR ORGANISED)

EASP Conference 2026, Strasbourg

- Presenter: “Does AI Face Harsher Moral Judgements? A Meta-Analysis” (Poster)

EASP Pre-Conference 2026, Strasbourg

- Attendee: Supported members of my network, expanded my professional connections, and contributed to discussions on the future of AI, such as whether it appears hopeful or concerning.

EASP Summer School Member 2025, Kent

- Member: Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Moral Psychology Work Stream
 - July 20-30 2025

Co-Organiser for ECR Conference 2025, Exeter (and Online)

- “Share, Connect, Grow: Psychology Research Conference”
 - Early Career Researcher (ECR) Conference, 18th June 2025.

Invited Panel Member 2025

- “You, Me, And AI: Developing a Considered and Resilient Mindset for an Ever-Changing World”
 - AI Upskilling for Digital Innovation and Employability, 3rd June 2025
 - Academic Panel Discussion alongside Dr Tyler Brunet and David Walker

PROFESSIONAL TRAINING

PsychoPy Workshop (2023)

- Led by: PsychoPy Founders
- Description: Completed a 3-day workshop applying Python coding skills to design behavioural and neurophysiological experiments in PsychoPy—the first open science tool for creating such experiments. Since then, I have developed both behavioural and neurophysiological experiments in PsychoPy. Due to its novelty, the features required for the EEG task I designed exceeded the GUI's capabilities, necessitating further development of my Python skills to manually code advanced experiments and features, including sending multiple and variable triggers.

Code First Girls (2023)

- Led by: Habib Sentongo and Xian-Ting Lee
- Description: Completed a 10-week “Introduction to Python and Apps” program, developing proficiency in Python. This supported my collaboration on a final project to use Python for data analysis on spreadsheet data.

RESEARCH OUTPUT

AI vs. Humans: Does AI Face Harsher Moral Judgments? A Meta-Analysis

- Hill-Cousins, O., Sweetman, J., & Lowe, C. J. (2026, June 4). AI vs. Humans: Does AI Face Harsher Moral Judgments? A Meta-Analysis. Retrieved from osf.io/preprints/psyarxiv/stcej

An Integrative Python Coding Solution For Sending Dynamic Intra- And Inter-Stimulus Triggers for Neuroexperiments

- Hill-Cousins, O. (2026, March 20). An Integrative Python Coding Solution for Sending Dynamic Intra- and Inter-Stimulus Triggers for Neuroexperiments. Retrieved from osf.io/preprints/psyarxiv/2fmbj

SKILLS & CERTIFICATIONS

Skills

- Coding behavioural and advanced EEG experiments in PsychoPy (Using Python & JavaScript coding languages)
- Data simulation, simulation-based power analyses, & statistical analysis using R
- Advanced multi-level meta-analytic methods
- Open science research
- MATLAB
- Coding in R, Python and LaTeX
- Coding in HTML and CSS to support reproducible workflows with R and Github

Certifications

- Learning and Teaching in Higher Education (LTHE)
- Introduction to Python and Apps (Code First Girls)
- Introduction to Python Programming Course (Dataquest.io)
- MATLAB Onramp (MathWorks)
- MATLAB Fundamentals (MathWorks)

- Machine Learning Onramp (MathWorks)
- Power BI for Beginners (Simplilearn)

